

1939–1945

FASHION ON RATION

In March 1941 the British government imposed austerity regulations limiting the amount of materials as well as features such as pleats and buttons that could be used in a garment's production. In June of the same year rationing was introduced to ensure clothes were allocated fairly. Ration books were issued, and set numbers of coupons had to be presented when buying clothing, cloth, footwear, and knitting yarn. More specific guidelines were applied to garments produced as part of the Utility Clothing Scheme. Clothes marked with the distinctive CC41 (Civilian Clothing 1941) label had to adhere to government-set quality standards and were price controlled. In May 1942 members of the Incorporated Society of London Fashion Designers were asked by the Board of Trade to contribute designs to a utility range to persuade women that austerity could be chic. British *Vogue* declared that the new silhouette, "straighter, trim and businesslike", was the only one to follow.

AUSTERITY SHOES

Leather was needed for army purposes, so an alternative material for shoe soles had to be found. Wooden soles could be bought coupon-free, but were disliked because they were stiff and noisy to walk in. Split wooden soles joined by a leather hinge were an attempt to solve the problems. The traditional Bavarian walking shoe, the *Haferlschuh*, provided the inspiration for a widely produced style that incorporated side lacing and piping in contrasting colours. On the footwear front, women were seen to be at a disadvantage as their shoes tended to wear out quicker than men's. There were complaints that women were using all the family's coupons.



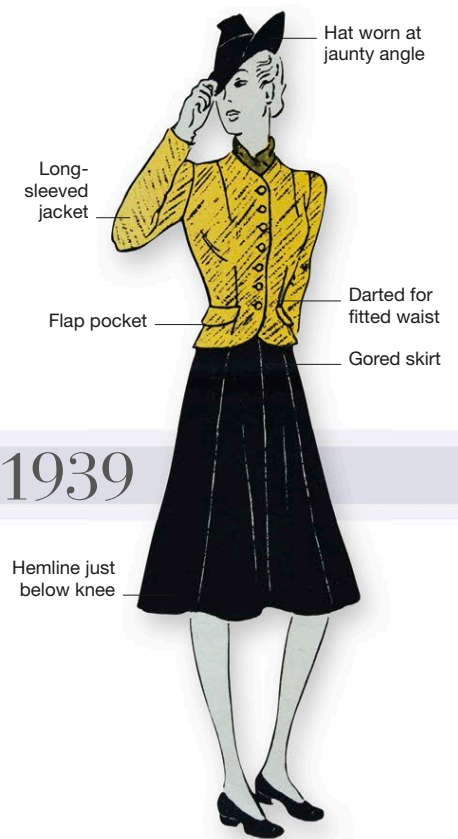
Hinged wooden sole



Utility lace-up

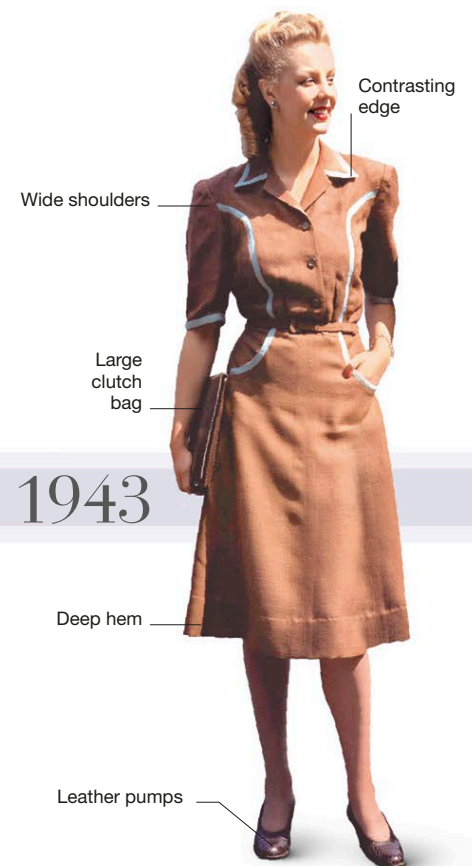


Moygashel Crease-resistant moygashel, an artificial fibre made from a viscose/polyester blend, was used for this dress. Patterned knitwear made use of many short lengths of wool, obtained by unravelling old garments.



1939

Short and full This *Vogue* pattern was published just as Britain declared war against Germany. The shortness of the skirt remained a feature of wartime clothing but its fullness was soon to become a thing of the past.



1943

Ready-to-wear When first asked to design for the ready-to-wear company Berketex, London couturier Norman Hartnell refused, believing it would harm his status. He later changed his mind and designed smart utility dresses.